cricket clubs: Maldon cricket club, where I grew up playing in Essex, Great Brickhill and Eversholt. Through them I have come to understand the role the game can play in strengthening the bonds of a community. Eversholt's setting is a combination of country and cricketing clichés. There is a small church, St John the Baptist, on the hill, dating back to Norman times. It was extended in 1230 and 1330; the first recorded baptism was in 1628. The village pub is opposite the graveyard, which has a memorial cross recording the sacrifice of two world wars.

The club operates from a small wooden pavilion and plays in a natural amphitheatre. Villagers watch from grassed banks while children play in an open-air swimming pool, built by a former duke of Bedford, apparently in return for the erection of a surrounding wall that enabled him to bathe naked in a nearby lake.

The first team is of a high standard and reached the final of the National Village Cup at Lord's in 2000. It has a thriving junior section; the outfield is full of youngsters on weekend mornings and weekday evenings.

It is imperative to try to help clubs and the values they can still represent. It is becoming harder to raise adult teams because family life isn't conducive to playing cricket all weekend. Children have greater opportunity, and modern life involves being here, there and everywhere.

It's a difficult dilemma to resolve. Cricket has given me everything. It has given me my life, really. I've travelled the world and had a vast range of experiences. Obviously, not everyone can go on to become an international, but the highs and lows of sport are educational. I wouldn't want our game to wither and die, because it would rob future generations of that type of opportunity.

It can still be a game of miracles and wonders. I sometimes think back fondly to the plastic sports radio Dad bought me when I was at St Paul's. I would listen to cricket in bed, through fragile headphones, under the covers. Test matches were broadcast on crackly Radio Four 198 long wave. You could vaguely hear Jonathan Agnew through the static; the rest was down to your imagination. It took you through time and space; games in New Zealand were being played tomorrow when it was still today.

How many of this generation of schoolboys will be lucky enough to be able to relate to my first cricket tour, to play in the Sir Garry Sobers forty-over tournament in Barbados? I was sixteen and accustomed to well-tended